

ENGLISH FOR WORK / SEPTEMBER 2026

Software Product Management English



Teacher's guide

Teach practical workplace communication with specific cases, clear language targets, and a repeatable feedback process.

PRACTICE THAT TRANSFERS TO WORK

Read a realistic case. Study complete conversations. Find the right language, speak, get feedback, and try again.

Eight lessons | Intermediate to advanced | Independent or classroom study

For software product managers, product owners, UX leads, engineering managers, growth product teams, platform PMs, and product-operations staff.

All cases and figures are fictional. Adapt the language to your role and organization's current procedures, using invented details for practice.

All scenarios, figures, and model responses are fictional teaching material. Use invented details in practice.

[Open this course on English Ladder](#)

Your course at a glance

Use the lesson numbers to match this document with the website and the other guides.

01 Product Discovery and Problem Framing

Clarify missing information before responding.

02 Roadmaps and Prioritization

Negotiate scope or timing while making conditions explicit.

03 User Stories and Acceptance Criteria

Make a request with a clear action, purpose, and realistic timing.

04 Metrics, Funnels, and Product Analytics

Explain a useful distinction in plain English.

05 Experimentation and A/B Testing

Separate observations, assumptions, and conclusions.

06 Release Readiness and Go-to-Market

Give a handoff that the receiving person can confirm.

07 Platform, APIs, and Technical Debt

Compare options using the same criteria and state the tradeoff.

08 Stakeholder Pushback and Executive Narrative

Include relevant voices and clarify the decision process.

Choose your pace

Quick practice: spend 15 minutes reading one conversation and rehearsing one scenario. Full lesson: allow 45-60 minutes for language work, three conversations, two speaking scenarios, and feedback.

Level support

B1 learners can use the frames and a partner. B2 learners can try a response before reading the model. C1 learners can add the harder follow-up and reduce preparation time. These are teaching suggestions, not certified CEFR level ratings.

After practicing: open the AI prompt workshop to choose a vocabulary, grammar, role-play, or new-dialogue activity.

A 60-minute lesson that works

Prepare the case and the learner pages. Keep the model response hidden until learners have attempted their own. Choose two field terms that are important to understanding the case.

0-5 minutes | Activate experience

Ask learners to name a comparable situation without sharing confidential details. Introduce the communication goal.

5-12 minutes | Read and sort facts

Read the case. Learners identify confirmed facts, unknowns, the audience, and the immediate communication need.

12-22 minutes | Notice and practice language

Explain the workshop pattern. Work through the vocabulary and editing example, then discuss both language checks and the reasons behind the choices.

22-35 minutes | 05 · Conversations

Read one ten-turn conversation aloud, notice a useful expression, then compare the other two. Identify each speaker's purpose and how the exchange ends.

35-47 minutes | 06 · Say it

Rehearse both speaking scenarios from the workbook. Give two minutes of preparation, switch roles, and use the success checks. Add the complication only after a successful first round.

47-55 minutes | Compare and revise

Reveal the model. Discuss alternative acceptable wording. Give one meaning correction and one language correction, then repeat.

55-60 minutes | Retrieve and transfer

Close the materials. Learners recall two expressions and identify one communication habit to use in another situation.

Adapt the session

For 45 minutes, study one complete conversation and rehearse one scenario; assign the others for oral follow-up. For 90 minutes, rehearse all three conversations and give both scenarios a second round. More time should produce more meaningful practice, not longer explanations.

LESSON 01 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Product Discovery and Problem Framing

Clarify missing information before responding.

CASE

A stakeholder requests a new button without explaining the user problem. Support notes mention difficulty finding an existing action.

Teach this move

Name the exact word, fact, or requirement you need clarified. Ask one focused question at a time. Repeat your understanding and give the other person a chance to correct it.

Vocabulary to check: user need, persona, use case, opportunity cost.

Model response

What is the user trying to achieve, and where do they get stuck? Let's examine that problem before deciding whether a new button is the right solution.

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. After an introductory phrase such as 'Could you explain', the embedded question uses statement word order: "what this means".

Second-round challenge

The other person uses an ambiguous word such as 'ready', 'approved', or 'urgent'. Clarify it before continuing.

Language-check answers

1. B - Could you confirm when the review starts? The embedded question uses subject then verb: "the review starts".
2. A - Has the report been approved, or is it ready for review? This question distinguishes two meanings of 'ready' that affect the next action.

05 • Conversations

1. Find the action before adding another button - Fictional discovery discussion using the lesson case: a stakeholder requests a button, while support notes describe difficulty finding an existing action.
2. Who needs the weekly digest? - Fictional discovery interview: a department lead requests a weekly email digest but has not identified recipients or decisions it should support.
3. A competitor feature is not a user problem - Fictional roadmap intake: a stakeholder asks for color-coded folders because a competitor offers them; no customer use case has been established.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 · Say it: second scenario | Why do users ask for printing?

A fictional support queue contains four requests for a print button. The records do not explain whether users need paper copies, portable files, or approval evidence. Clarify the use case before proposing a feature.

Role A: Product manager: ask what task sits behind the request.

Role B: Support lead: explain the limited evidence and offer to follow up with the requesters.

Possible opening: We have four requests for printing, but we haven't established what users need the output for.

Success checks

- Separate requested solution from underlying need.
- Identify missing audience and task information.
- Agree a focused follow-up without promising implementation.

Add a complication: A stakeholder says four identical feature requests prove one identical need.

LESSON 02 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Roadmaps and Prioritization

Negotiate scope or timing while making conditions explicit.

CASE

A roadmap has three large features and capacity for two. All three sponsors describe their request as urgent.

Teach this move

Acknowledge the goal and explain the available choices. Connect an offer to its actual conditions. A useful response makes room for discussion without promising approval or resources you do not control.

Vocabulary to check: roadmap, prioritization, dependency, capacity.

Model response

We have capacity for two features in this period. Could we compare the expected outcomes and dependencies, then agree which item moves? Calling all three urgent does not resolve the capacity choice.

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. For an ordinary future condition, the "if" clause uses present tense. The other clause can express the future consequence or possibility.

Second-round challenge

The preferred option is unavailable. Offer an alternative and clearly state any approval still needed.

Language-check answers

1. A - If the scope changes, we will review the schedule. The "if" clause uses present tense; the main clause states the future response.
2. C - We can assess the addition and explain its effect on the agreed scope. This offers a useful next step while keeping the approval and scope question open.

05 · Conversations

1. Three priorities, capacity for two - Separate fictional roadmap case: saved filters, bulk export, and team templates each require four team-weeks. Eight team-weeks are available this quarter. Engineering has also assessed a personal-template slice at two team-weeks. Later capacity and stakeholder approval are unconfirmed.

2. A dependency changes the order, not the goal - Fictional planning: a new reporting view depends on an account-permissions update; both are proposed for the same planning period.

3. Urgent intake after the roadmap is agreed - Fictional product planning: a new sponsor requests a bulk-edit feature after the team has committed its available capacity; no estimate exists.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 · Say it: second scenario | A smaller pilot instead of a full rollout

A fictional product team can assess a pilot for one department or a full rollout to four. Estimates and support needs are not yet known. A sponsor wants all four immediately. Negotiate the information and conditions needed for a smaller option.

Role A: Product manager: offer a pilot assessment without guaranteeing its delivery date.

Role B: Sponsor: explain the desired reach and consider a bounded first step.

Possible opening: Could we assess a one-department pilot while we clarify the capacity and support needs for all four?

Success checks

- Distinguish pilot scope from full rollout.
- Keep estimates and capacity unconfirmed.
- Agree the evidence needed for prioritization.

Add a complication: The sponsor wants the pilot labeled a complete rollout on the roadmap.

LESSON 03 / FACILITATOR NOTES

User Stories and Acceptance Criteria

Make a request with a clear action, purpose, and realistic timing.

CASE

A user story says the page should load "quickly." The team needs a testable completion condition.

Teach this move

State the action and the information needed. Explain why it matters and specify a deadline only when one is given or agreed. 'Could you' is polite; repeated apologies can obscure a legitimate request. Urgent situations may require a direct request.

Vocabulary to check: user story, acceptance criteria, edge case, definition of done.

Model response

Could we define the relevant user journey, measurement conditions, and acceptable response time? That will make the acceptance criteria clear enough for development and testing.

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. The revision names the document and requested response. It avoids expressions that may be unfamiliar or ambiguous for an international audience.

Second-round challenge

The other person cannot meet the requested timing. Clarify an alternative without inventing authority to change a formal deadline.

Language-check answers

1. C - Send it no later than Thursday. 'By' sets the latest point, while 'after' refers to a later time.
2. B - Could you confirm the document version needed for the review? The requested action and information are explicit.

05 · Conversations

1. Make quickly testable - Fictional refinement using the lesson case: a user story says a page should load quickly without defining a measurable completion condition.
2. What should happen when there are no results? - Fictional search-story review: the story describes displaying matching records but says nothing about a search with zero matches.

3. Saved locally or shared with the team? - Fictional story discussion: a requirement says save the filter, but does not specify whether it belongs to one user or the whole team.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 · Say it: second scenario | Cancel after an upload starts

A fictional upload story includes a Cancel control, but its behavior after transfer begins is undefined. No cancellation semantics have been approved. Request a bounded acceptance-criteria discussion covering user feedback and the saved-item state.

Role A: Quality engineer: ask what cancellation should mean at this stage.

Role B: Product owner: identify the decision needed and coordinate with engineering.

Possible opening: Could we define what Cancel does after transfer starts, including what the user sees afterward?

Success checks

- Distinguish visual feedback from actual item state.
- Request clear conditions before testing.
- Agree a review owner and realistic discussion point.

Add a complication: A colleague says any disappearance of the progress bar should count as success.

LESSON 04 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Metrics, Funnels, and Product Analytics

Explain a useful distinction in plain English.

CASE

A product dashboard shows more sign-ups but fewer users completing setup. A stakeholder calls the acquisition campaign a complete success.

Teach this move

Start with the reader's question. Explain one unfamiliar term with familiar words, then give a relevant example or contrast. Check understanding without asking only 'Do you understand?'.

Vocabulary to check: activation, retention, funnel, cohort.

Model response

Sign-ups increased, but setup completion fell. These metrics describe different stages of the funnel. Let's examine the full journey before concluding that the change improved the intended user outcome.

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. The revised sentence names the action in familiar words. Specialist vocabulary is useful when it adds precision, but repeating abstract nouns can hide the meaning.

Second-round challenge

Your listener is new to this field. Replace two specialist expressions with clear explanations without changing the meaning.

Language-check answers

1. B - The backlog is the work still waiting to be completed. This gives the meaning in familiar words.
2. A - How would you describe the next step in your own words? An open request lets the listener show their understanding.

05 • Conversations

1. More sign-ups, fewer completed setups - Fictional analytics discussion using the lesson case: sign-ups increased but fewer users completed setup; a stakeholder calls the campaign a complete success.
2. A returning visit is not the defined retention event - Fictional product dashboard: retention is defined as completing a project task in a later week, but a draft counts any returning page view.

3. A younger cohort has had less time - Fictional funnel review: an older sign-up cohort has seven days of setup observation; a newer cohort has only two days.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 · Say it: second scenario | One user makes five accounts

A fictional sign-up dashboard counts accounts, while an activation report counts unique people. One test participant created five accounts. The extent of multiple accounts elsewhere is unknown. Explain why the two measures cannot be treated as the same unit.

Role A: Product analyst: explain accounts versus people.

Role B: Growth lead: ask what definition and reconciliation are needed.

Possible opening: The sign-up figure counts accounts, but the activation report counts people, so their units differ.

Success checks

- Distinguish the counting units.
- Avoid generalizing from one participant.
- Agree a consistent definition before comparing funnel stages.

Add a complication: The growth lead proposes dividing every account total by five.

LESSON 05 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Experimentation and A/B Testing

Separate observations, assumptions, and conclusions.

CASE

An A/B test shows a higher conversion rate in one version after one day. The planned test duration has not elapsed.

Teach this move

Say what the evidence shows, identify what is still unknown, and limit the conclusion to that evidence. Words such as 'may', 'suggests', and 'in this sample' are useful when the uncertainty is real. Do not soften an urgent, verified safety concern.

Vocabulary to check: A/B test, hypothesis, guardrail metric, statistical significance.

Model response

The early observed rate is higher, but the planned test is incomplete. I'll report it as an interim result and check the agreed analysis and guardrail measures before recommending a decision.

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. The revision states the finding and its scope. It avoids turning limited evidence into a universal claim.

Second-round challenge

Someone asks for a yes-or-no answer when the evidence supports only a qualified answer. Be concise while preserving the uncertainty.

Language-check answers

1. A - The change may have contributed to the delay. 'May have contributed' presents a possibility without claiming the cause is established.
2. C - In this pilot, the observed result was ... This locates the finding in the setting actually studied.

05 · Conversations

1. One day of lift is not a completed test - Fictional A/B-test review using the lesson case: one version has higher conversion after one day, before the planned duration ends.
2. Conversion improves while support contacts rise - Fictional experiment readout: the treatment shows higher conversion and more support contacts; uncertainty and the prespecified guardrail evaluation are pending.

3. The test changed two things at once - Fictional product experiment: version B changes both a headline and button placement; the observed conversion rate is higher than version A.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 · Say it: second scenario | The slide and dashboard disagree on the treatment label

A fictional test dashboard identifies the treatment as B, but a draft slide calls A the treatment. No published readout has been sent. Discuss how to verify assignments and correct the presentation before interpreting results.

Role A: Experiment analyst: request the assignment record and treatment definition.

Role B: Product manager: pause the conclusion and confirm the correction route.

Possible opening: The slide and dashboard disagree about the treatment label, so we need to verify assignment before interpreting the result.

Success checks

- Verify labels from the source record.
- Do not select a treatment identity from outcome size.
- Agree a corrected readout with uncertainty and guardrails retained.

Add a complication: A stakeholder says the larger number can simply be labeled the winner.

LESSON 06 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Release Readiness and Go-to-Market

Give a handoff that the receiving person can confirm.

CASE

A release is ready for review, but the support team has not received migration notes. The launch checklist lists them as required.

Teach this move

State the current situation, relevant background, open task, and receiving role. Ask for acknowledgment or repeat-back of the critical item. Sending a message and transferring responsibility are not always the same thing.

Vocabulary to check: release, rollback, enablement, migration.

Model response

The product checks are ready for review; support preparation is still open. I'll send the migration notes and ask the support owner to confirm readiness before the launch decision.

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. The revised sentence asks for an identifiable receiving team instead of leaving responsibility with an unspecified 'someone'.

Second-round challenge

The intended recipient cannot take ownership. Keep the status clear and identify the need for an authorized reassignment.

Language-check answers

1. C - Please confirm who will complete the outstanding check. It asks for an identifiable person or team responsible for the task.
2. B - So the result is pending and your team will follow up; is that correct? This repeats the status and responsibility and invites correction.

05 • Conversations

1. Support has not received the migration notes - Fictional release handoff using the lesson case: a release is ready for review, but required migration notes have not reached support.

2. A rollback link points to the previous release - Fictional release preparation: the current checklist links to a previous release's rollback notes; applicability has not been checked.

3. Feature enabled is not customer migration complete - Fictional staged launch: a feature flag is enabled for a pilot group, while migration confirmation from that group is pending.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 · Say it: second scenario | The receiving team cannot access the demo

A fictional support-enablement session needs a demonstration environment. The release notes are available, but support accounts cannot enter the demo. No training has occurred. Give a handoff and agree the missing readiness check.

Role A: Release coordinator: acknowledge the access gap and name the next owner request.

Role B: Support lead: confirm received notes without claiming training completion.

Possible opening: We have the release notes, but demo access is blocked, so support practice has not happened yet.

Success checks

- Distinguish attendance, access, and completed practice.
- Request an access update through the proper owner.
- Confirm readiness remains pending the necessary handoff checks.

Add a complication: A manager wants attendance at the scheduled session counted as completed enablement.

LESSON 07 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Platform, APIs, and Technical Debt

Compare options using the same criteria and state the tradeoff.

CASE

A team can add a requested feature quickly using a workaround or spend longer improving the underlying interface.

Teach this move

Use the same time period, scope, and measurement basis for both options. Explain a difference with 'whereas' or 'while'. State what improves and what is given up; do not hide the weaker side of a recommendation.

Vocabulary to check: technical debt, API, platform, reliability.

Model response

The workaround is faster initially, while the interface change may reduce future maintenance. Let's compare delivery time, reliability, and ongoing cost instead of considering only the first release date.

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. 'Better' already has comparative meaning, so it does not need 'more'. Naming the criterion and tradeoff makes the comparison useful.

Second-round challenge

Your listener focuses only on the lowest price or fastest date. Explain one other relevant comparison criterion.

Language-check answers

1. B - Option A is faster, whereas option B costs less. 'Whereas' marks a contrast between two options.
2. A - An increase of one percentage point. Subtracting 6% from 7% gives one percentage point. The relative increase is about 16.7%.

05 · Conversations

1. Fast workaround or a stronger interface - Fictional platform discussion using the lesson case: a workaround could deliver sooner, while improving the underlying interface would take longer.
2. One customer exception or a reusable API change - Fictional platform planning: one customer requests an extra response field; the team can assess a customer-specific exception or a shared API change.

3. A manual retry hides recurring maintenance work - Fictional product operations: a failing import sometimes succeeds after a manual retry; the cause and frequency are not yet quantified.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 · Say it: second scenario | Supporting two API versions

A fictional platform supports version 1, and a proposed version 2 would simplify a new feature. Existing customer migration effort is unknown. Compare maintaining both versions with a reviewed migration approach without announcing a retirement date.

Role A: Platform product manager: outline common comparison criteria.

Role B: Customer-success lead: raise unknown migration and support needs.

Possible opening: Version two may simplify the feature, but we haven't assessed what existing customers need to migrate.

Success checks

- Compare delivery, maintenance, compatibility, and customer effort.
- Keep migration assumptions explicit.
- Avoid promising retirement or migration dates without assessment.

Add a complication: A stakeholder says a newer version makes migration effort irrelevant.

LESSON 08 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Stakeholder Pushback and Executive Narrative

Include relevant voices and clarify the decision process.

CASE

Two executives disagree about a product decision. The meeting has competing opinions but no shared criterion.

Teach this move

Summarize the issue neutrally, invite missing perspectives, and distinguish discussion from decision. State who can decide and record any unresolved question. Do not assume silence means agreement.

Vocabulary to check: stakeholder, strategic fit, tradeoff, decision memo.

Model response

Could we agree on the outcome and decision criteria first? Then we can compare the options against them, record the tradeoff, and confirm who will make the final decision.

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. The revised question gives people a way to raise a concern. Silence can have several meanings, especially in unfamiliar or unequal-power situations.

Second-round challenge

A participant interrupts or the meeting is running out of time. Protect a turn to speak and close with an accurate decision record.

Language-check answers

1. A - We haven't heard from the remote team yet; what is your view? It invites participation without interpreting silence as consent.
2. C - Approval is pending; the sponsor will review the two options. This distinguishes discussion from approval and identifies the next reviewer.

05 • Conversations

1. Agree a criterion before choosing a feature - Fictional executive discussion using the lesson case: two executives favor different product options without a shared decision criterion.

2. Revenue potential and onboarding effort - Fictional product review: sales favors a specialist feature, while customer success questions onboarding effort; neither impact estimate is verified.

3. A loud meeting does not equal stakeholder agreement - Fictional product meeting: an executive strongly supports a redesign; the accessibility lead has not spoken and review findings remain unknown.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 · Say it: second scenario | A strategic-fit claim without a named objective

A fictional proposal is described as strategically essential, but the sponsor has not identified which current product objective it supports. The team has two competing proposals. Facilitate a short comparison and clarify the decision route.

Role A: Product manager: ask for the objective and relevant evidence.

Role B: Executive sponsor: explain the intended outcome while acknowledging the missing comparison.

Possible opening: Which product objective does this proposal support, and what criterion should we use to compare it with the alternative?

Success checks

- Connect strategic fit to a named objective or an explicit gap.
- Preserve the relevant competing perspective.
- Agree criteria and decision ownership without implying approval.

Add a complication: The sponsor asks you to omit the alternative from the decision discussion.

Give feedback that helps

Score each criterion 0, 1, or 2. This is a practice rubric, not a professional qualification or CEFR test. Do not award or remove points for a particular accent.

Meaning and accuracy

Keeps the case facts accurate; clearly separates confirmed and unknown information.

Clarity and language

Uses understandable sentences and explains specialist terms when the listener needs it.

Interaction and tone

Responds to the other person's question, checks understanding, and uses an appropriate tone.

Task completion

Makes the requested action or unresolved question clear without inventing authority or facts.

Use the same scale for each criterion

0 - Not yet: The reader or listener cannot yet recover the intended meaning or action.

1 - With support: The message works after a prompt, clarification, or revision.

2 - Independently: The message is clear and accurate without a prompt.

Feedback sequence

First, identify a successful phrase. Next, identify one point where meaning or accuracy needs work. Offer one useful language correction, allow a repeat, and compare the two attempts. A total out of eight describes this performance only; do not translate it into a proficiency level.

Final challenge

Choose a case not rehearsed today. The learner gives a one-minute response, answers two follow-up questions, and writes a 70-110 word message. Add the lesson's second-round challenge. Compare the result with an earlier attempt using the four criteria.

Use the language responsibly

All cases and figures are fictional. Adapt the language to your role and organization's current procedures, using invented details for practice.

Meaning before performance

Use specialist terms only when they help the listener. Explain unfamiliar words, preserve uncertainty, and ask when an instruction or responsibility is unclear. The model responses illustrate language; they do not authorize professional actions.

Sources and further reading

The cases, workshops, and explanations are original teaching material. These references provide language frameworks and selected professional context. References were checked in September 2026; consult current local guidance for actual work.

Digital.gov: plain-language guidance

<https://digital.gov/guides/plain-language>

Council of Europe: CEFR descriptors

<https://www.coe.int/en/web/common-european-framework-reference-languages/cefr-descriptors>

Your next step

Choose one expression you can use in a genuine work situation. Rehearse it with fictional details, then adapt the wording to your role and audience.